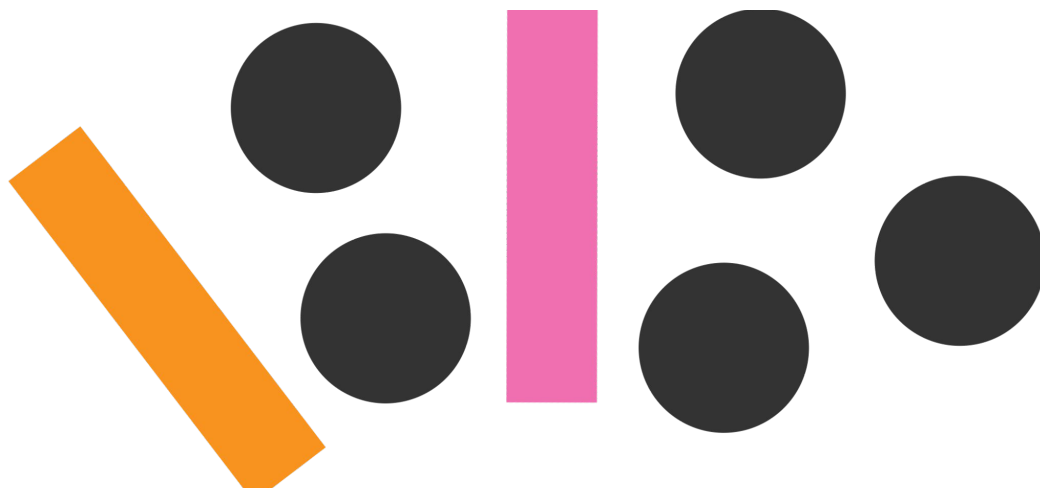


MAKE-BELIEVE FOUNDATION gUG



Make-Believe Foundation gUG: Profile Description

The Make-Believe Foundation gUG (haftungsbeschränkt) (formerly School of Machines) is a project space centered on art, technology, design, and human connection. It was founded in Berlin in 2014 and achieved non-profit status in 2023.

We run publicly accessible in-person and online programs that allow artists to develop, research, produce, and exhibit works that express who they are and what they care about. We feel this is our unique contribution: to provide those we engage with a safe space with which to question the world and themselves, and through this experience, we encourage artists to say something meaningful with their work.

We are a women-run project space and our event participants are over 60% women and from over 52 countries. We maintain a balance of free to the public and ticketed events and ensure diversity through targeted invitations to people from under-represented communities, scholarships, and solidarity tickets. As we ourselves come from diverse backgrounds, we feel it is part of our mission to expand access to tools for creative and critical purposes to those who don't often have opportunities to access it.

We use art to inspire empathy, self-reflection and artistic expression, empowering individuals to create meaningful works that addresses who they are and what they care about. Our goal is to foster better societies by encouraging personal growth and critical engagement with current events through art.

Our methodology begins by identifying relevant technologies, such as computer vision, and linking it to a societal theme, like surveillance. We design hands-on programs in which participants learn to use these tools while exploring their broader implications, such as military use, or border control. Participants then produce artworks reflecting real-world concerns while using tools that have the potential to both uplift and oppress us.

This approach highlights the power of socially engaged art, bridging humans, technology, and the sociopolitical landscape. By connecting art with modern tools and pressing issues, we emphasize its role in shaping a more thoughtful and aware society.

Make-Believe Foundation gUG: School of Humans

Continued Development of School of Humans

We are excited by the continued exploration and development of School of Humans, an organization conceived of to give more peer-to-peer support for artists and other creatives, to explore varying themes related to our human experience and turning those experiences into data and artworks. Themes we have previously explored are:

- What does it mean to be human?
- In the face of growing challenges, how can we help each other survive these hard times ahead?
- What does 'power' mean to us as a collective?

We, along with our six inaugural fellows, would like to continue research and explorations in a similar vein while also finding ways for creative output.

This inaugural group fellows are spending one year together meeting regularly and designing conversational experiences, and from those experiences creating artworks, slowly opening it up to a more public wider audience. Additionally, we will design a conference around these topics integrating conversation as data and socially engaged art. Support from you will allow us to develop this properly, with the care these topics deserve.

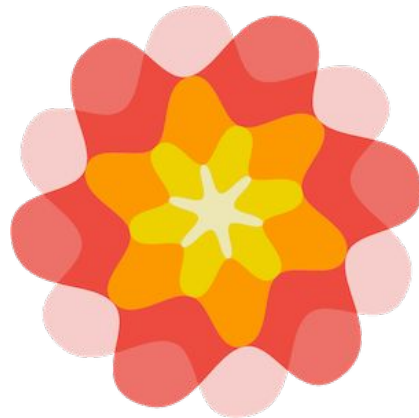
Make-Believe Foundation gUG: Presentation of activities

Mars College Berlin Digital Artist Residency Jan. 2025 - Apr. 2025

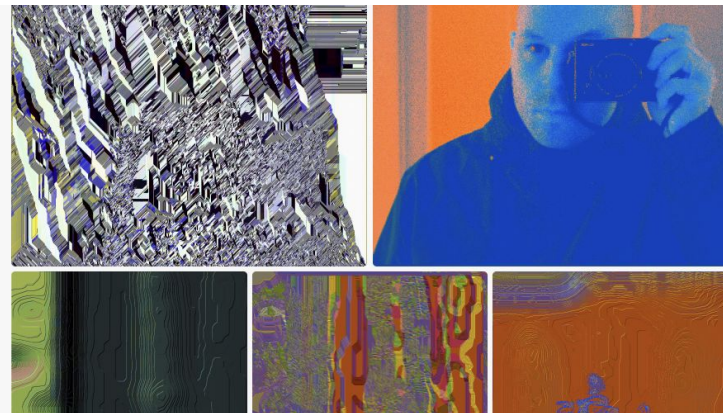
Mars College is an alternative research, art and education community in the California Desert. We created a Mars College Berlin cohort this January, inviting local artists for a diy self-hosted experimental peer learning residency in the areas of art, technology, and beyond. With a cohort of 16 local artists, we have weekly gatherings to share art and food, we run communal workshops, lead group outings to exhibitions, shows, nature walks, etc., and co-work and co-create. We are working towards a group exhibition in early summer 2025.



Group photo from our first Mars Berlin gathering at School of Machines.



Mars College Logo



Images from collective project exploring a convolutional algorithm tool that distorts image pixels

Make-Believe Foundation gUG: Presentation of activities

Digital Zines / Online galleries

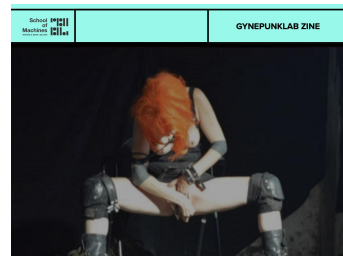
Over the years we have created zines and digital galleries as output for various programs, to go more in-depth on the concepts we are exploring within a class than can be shown on the website itself, and to showcase the work of School of Machines in general. Below are a sampling of recent and past works. Click on the images for direct links. Enjoy! :)



Our first online showcase in times of COVID. Including artworks on topics of personal games, natural machines, and more!



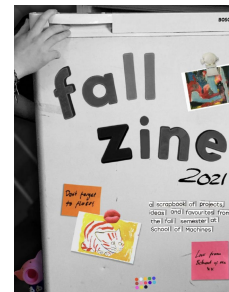
Online exhibition representing generative and NFT artworks. The online opening included performative sound elements and interactivity.



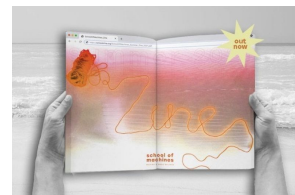
Exploring gynecology, medical violence, and diy tools. In collaboration with Klau Chinche, 2025.



Exploring disconnecting from digital. In collaboration with Alistair Alexander, 2025.



Showcasing artworks from our online courses and events of 2021, topics include AI, generative art, wearables and more!



A snapshot of a few of the programs, projects, and people that joined us in Spring/Summer 2021 on topics including algorithmic poetry, data art, and drones.

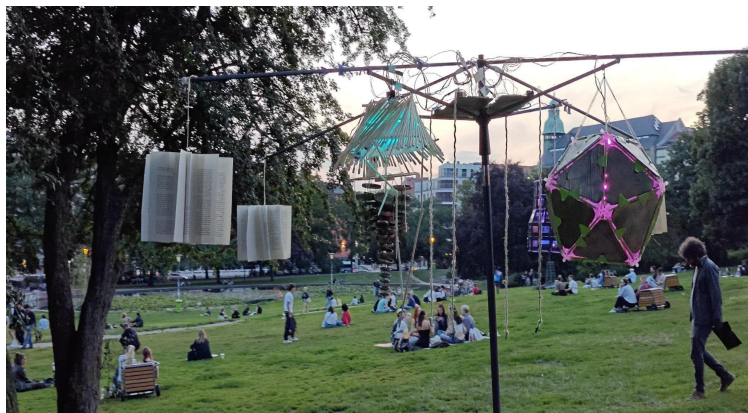
Make-Believe Foundation gUG: Presentation of activities

July Summer Program (2022-2024)

For three consecutive summers, we held “Interactive Berlin”, a program that explored taking art outside of the gallery into public space through the use of various electronics, microcontrollers and fabrication techniques. After a four week hands-on lab program, artists exhibited their works in Volkspark am Weinberg, Berlin. Themes included the botanical history of the park, queer intimacy, radio technologies, experimental mediation, bodies, AI and more.



Maria Jose Diaz, *Queer Kissing Booth*, Volkspark am Weinberg, Berlin, 2023



Machiel Veltkamp, *Totem of Rituals and Enigmatic Entities (T.R.E.E.)*, Volkspark am Weinberg, Berlin, 2024

(left) Jessica Renee Samut, *Fuck It, I Made a Butt Fountain*, Volkspark am Weinberg, Berlin, 2024



(right) So Young Song, *Can I Please Listen to Myself?*, Volkspark am Weinberg, Berlin, 2024



Make-Believe Foundation gUG: Presentation of activities



Mario Guzman [MX], *Consciousness Is The Foreknowledge of the Universal Mind*, addresses the perception of consciousness thru the body, sound and voice in the field of AI.



aBe Pazos [FI/ES], *A Life Cycle*, visualizes organic, emerging structures of birth, growth, decay, and death reflecting artificial life forms.



Paloma Oliveira & Mateus Knelsen [BR] *Realejo*, reimagines the classic Brazilian mechanical organ by using AI and animatronics technology as experiment to restore old traditional with modern technology.

August 9 to August 26, 2024, AAAAAAH!, Kunstquartier Bethanien, Berlin: This exhibition featured 13 art installations, eight short films, five interactive net art pieces, and one VR experience. The majority of these works were created specifically for the show, exploring themes ranging from the human body to data and surveillance. The curatorial perspective centered on the ethos of the Make-Believe Foundation: using art and technology as critical tools to express profound truths about the human experience.

Press: Holo, August 9, 2024:

<https://www.holo.mg/stream/school-of-machines-making-make-belief-anniversary-kunst-quartier-bethanien/>

Make-Believe Foundation gUG: Presentation of activities

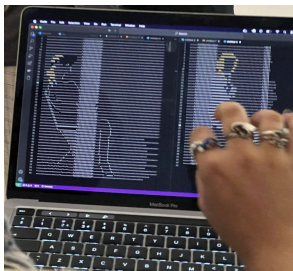
August 9 to August 26, 2024, AAAAAAH!, Kunstquartier Bethanien, Berlin: As part of this 10 year anniversary exhibition, we invited past participants of our programs to give workshops that reflected both their art practice and current events:



To Fly Another Day was a two-part collective artmaking and performance event that encouraged participants and viewers to reflect together on the themes of survival: resilience, adaptability, hope, fragility, and strength. Participants engaged in a shared creative process by making kites, then showcasing the fruits of their collaboration by flying their kites in the park.

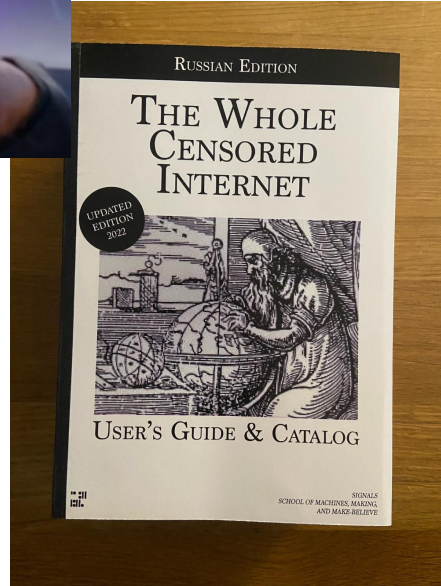


Robot Arm & P5: Exploring Human and Machine Creativity through Mandala Art was a workshop for artists to explore the collaborative possibilities between humans and machines through the co-creation of mandala art using a robotic arm and open-source tools.



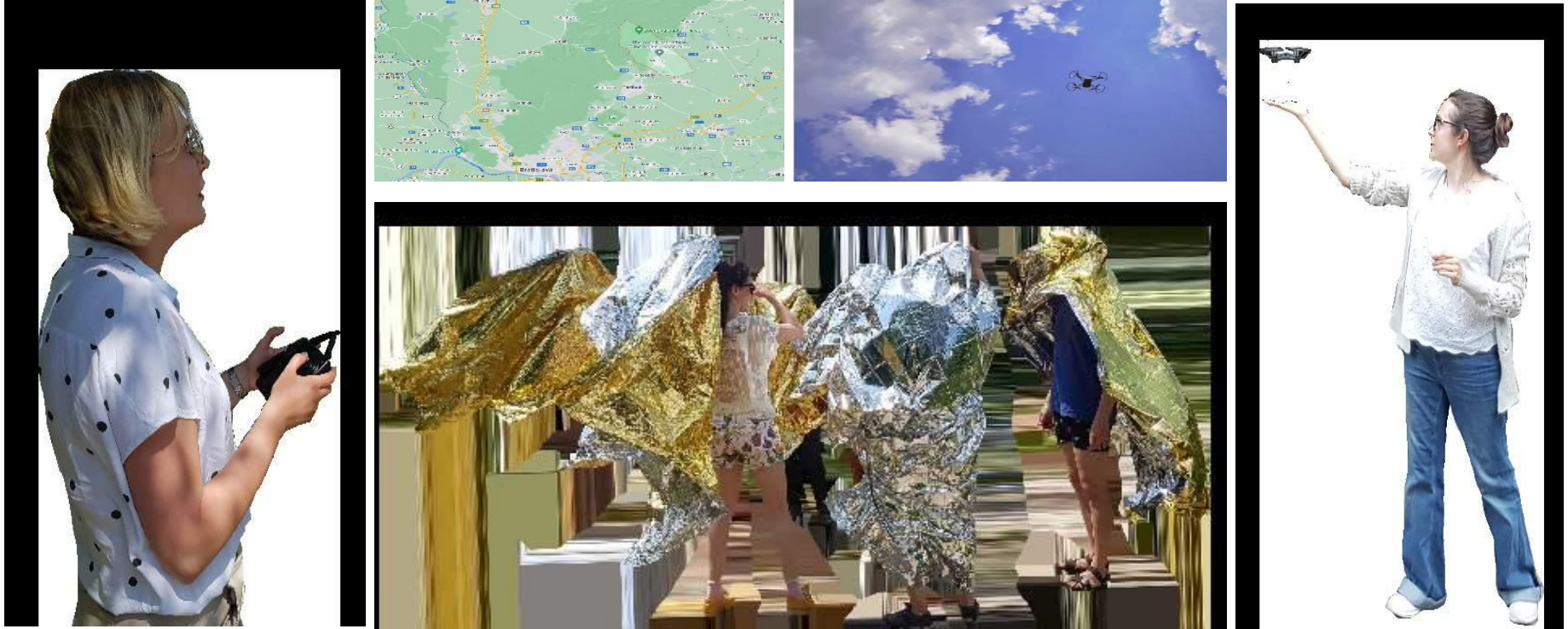
Experimental life drawing with technology across the Digital Divide was a life drawing event with a twist. We invited artists to explore how digital tools and even coding could be combined with the artistic tradition of close observation from nature. Artists used the opportunity to consider the human body as it relates to machines and the digital world.

Curated Exhibitions and Programs: Signals



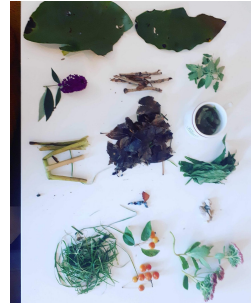
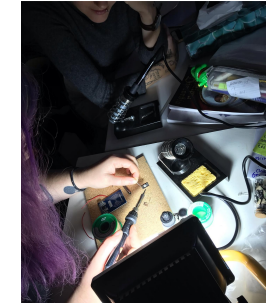
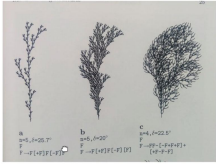
Signals: Networks and Artistic Interventions, May 16 to 27, 2022 with exhibition at Oyouun from June 3 to 24, 2022. A program made possible with support from Hauptstadt Kulturfonds, which explored hidden communication in times of authoritarian regimes. Projects include the Whole Censored Internet, Russian Edition, and Coordinated°, an award winning project using drones to decentralise communication during protest, plus secret Spotify playlist messages, hidden communication inside plastic toys, refrigerators that recite laws, a NO WARS piano composition in morse code, and more.

Curated Exhibitions and Programs: Videodrone



Videodrone: Borders, Humans, Technology, and Aerial Videography, July 7 to July 1, 2021: A culture program which ran in Slovakia made possible through V4 funding with Sensorium Festival in Bratislava and other partners in Poland, Hungary, and Czech Republic in which we invited participants from each country to join us in exploring the use of video drones for art and performance alongside themes of culture, politics, and borders.

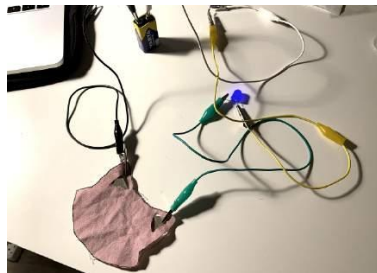
Curated Exhibitions and Programs: Natural Machines and Waiting and Escaping



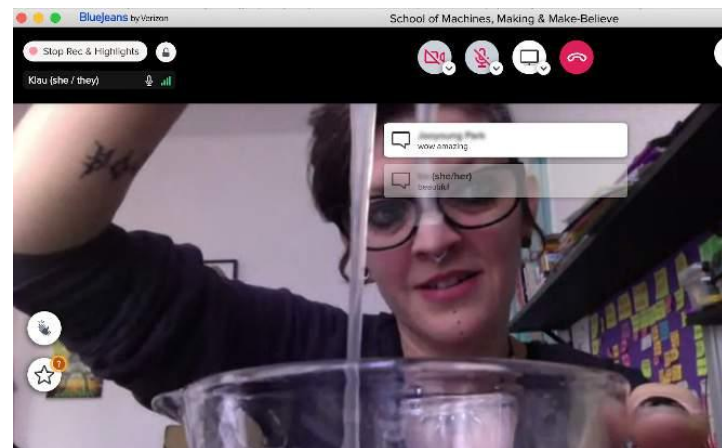
Natural Machines: Nature, Generative Art, and Machine Learning, August 31 to September 25, 2020. This program explored the question, *'How can nature inform our understanding of machines?'*

Waiting and Escaping: Designing Spatial Experiences for Waiting and Escape Rooms, 30. September to 25. October, 2019 explored how to enhance experiences of immersion. 11

Curated Online Courses: Code Biophilia and GynePunkLab

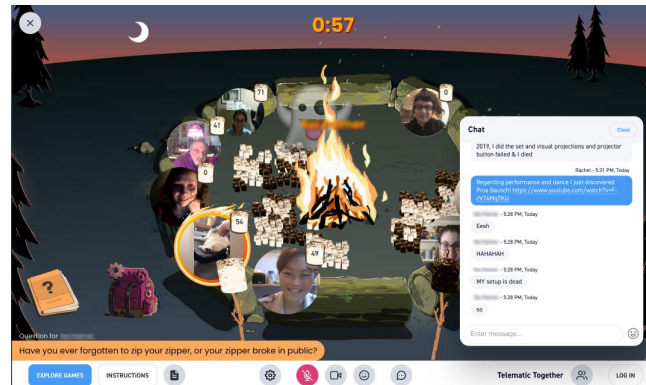
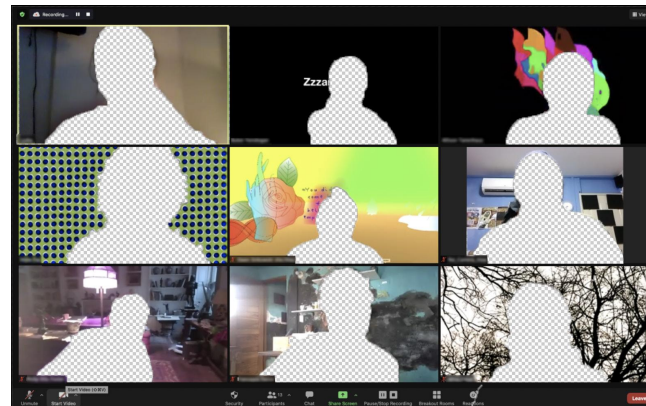
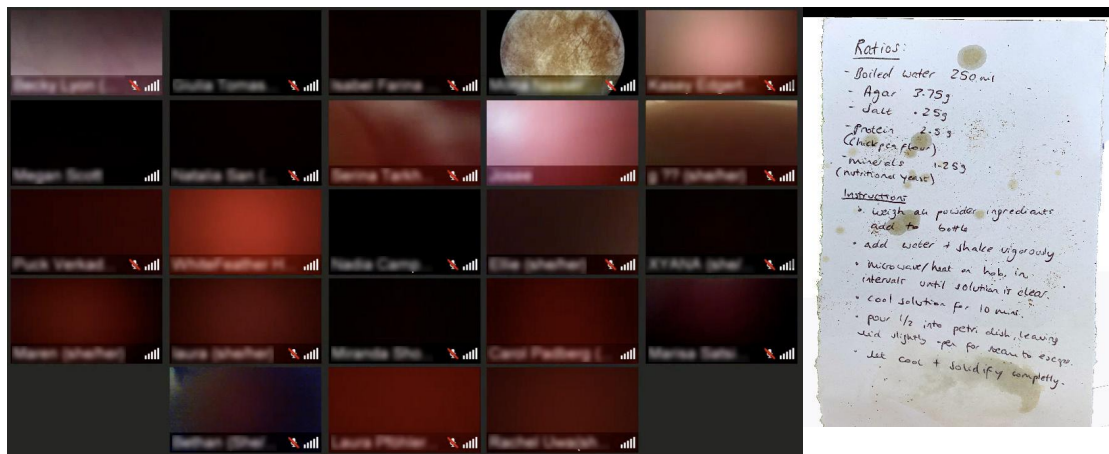


Coded Biophilia, exploring soft wearables and biological textiles, October 27 to November 22, 2021 (with kits mailed to participants)



GynePunkLab, transhackfeminist health tools for self-defense and healing justice, October 14 to November 12, 2021

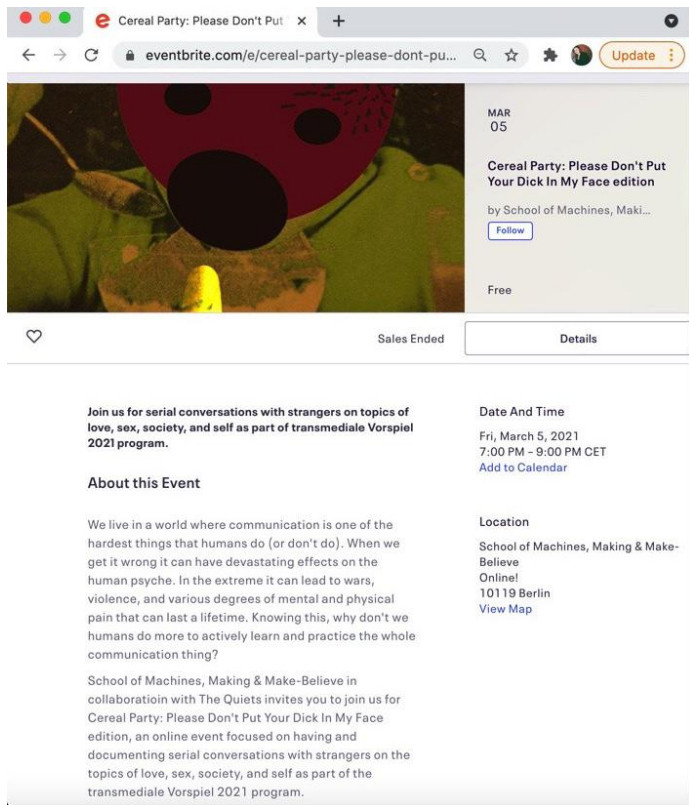
Curated Online Courses: BioArt Coven and Telematic Together



BioArt Coven, surveying and creating at the intersection of contemporary witchcraft, feminism, and biotechnologies, October 14 to November 12, 2021

Telematic Together, creative expressions in online performance, October 14 to November 12, 2021

Curated Project: Cereal Parties



The screenshot shows the Eventbrite page for the event "Cereal Party: Please Don't Put Your Dick In My Face edition" by School of Machines, Maki-Believe. The event is scheduled for March 5, 2021, at 7:00 PM - 9:00 PM CET, and is free. The page includes a description of the event, which is a collaboration with The Quiets, focused on having and documenting serial conversations with strangers on topics of love, sex, society, and self as part of the transmediale Vorspiel 2021 program. The event is online, taking place at 10119 Berlin.

Cereal Party: Please Don't Put Your Dick In My Face edition
by School of Machines, Maki-Believe

Join us for serial conversations with strangers on topics of love, sex, society, and self as part of transmediale Vorspiel 2021 program.

About this Event

We live in a world where communication is one of the hardest things that humans do (or don't do). When we get it wrong it can have devastating effects on the human psyche. In the extreme it can lead to wars, violence, and various degrees of mental and physical pain that can last a lifetime. Knowing this, why don't we humans do more to actively learn and practice the whole communication thing?

School of Machines, Making & Make-Believe in collaboration with The Quiets invites you to join us for Cereal Party: Please Don't Put Your Dick In My Face edition, an online event focused on having and documenting serial conversations with strangers on the topics of love, sex, society, and self as part of the transmediale Vorspiel 2021 program.

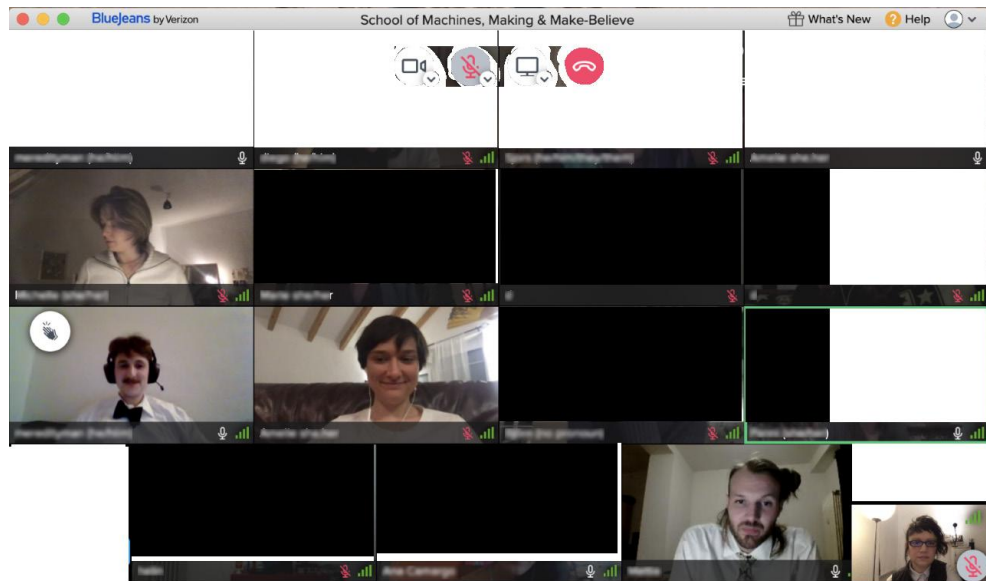
Date And Time
Fri, March 5, 2021
7:00 PM - 9:00 PM CET
[Add to Calendar](#)

Location
School of Machines, Making & Make-Believe
Online!
10119 Berlin
[View Map](#)

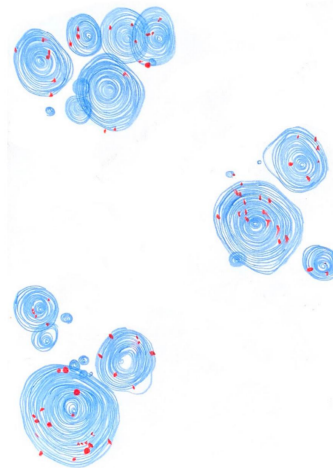


The invitation and images from the Cereal Party on March 5, 2021 (online). Cereal Party tagline: 5 strangers, 5 minutes, and a bowl of cereal over one shared conversation. Plus images from the first Cereal Party event which took place during transmediale Vorspiel opening night 2016.

Curated Project: The Quiets



Cereal Party



A Quiet Reflection by Michelle O'Higgins

"To attend this event as a Quiet was a refreshing opportunity to observe silently as a fly on the wall during a series of intimate online conversations between strangers. Applying such an intense attentiveness to a digital conversation that otherwise would be fighting for my attention amongst a sea of open tabs, meant that suddenly every stutter, interruption and nervous laugh came tumbling out of the screen and onto paper. The first data visualisation that you see on the left depicts the conversation between 3 individuals, attempting to record the length of time each participant spoke for and the frequency of interruptions of the male speakers versus the female speaker, with the red dots denoting instances of laughter. The second visualisation (next page) describes time passing as a continuous line snaking down the page, broken up by periods of silence and punctuated by symbols that record the frequency of laughter, interruptions and glitches.

While we might come to think of virtual interaction as an experience of disconnection, felt through laggy wifi and over-apologetic interruptions, these conversations revealed the opposite to be true. Perhaps the physical distance between us in cyberspace can open up for an honesty and volubility that we might be less willing to inhabit when we are so implicated in the dynamics of a room. So maybe in these moments of conversing digitally with strangers, we can practise giving words to difficult truths in hopes that they might jump off the tips of our tongues next time we meet."



The Quiets are a personal data collection and silent observation agency created in 2015 out of our Facts and Fictions in the Age of Data course. In the screenshot above (*left*), a few Quiets attended a Cereal Party to document the intimate conversations taking place about love, sex and technology (*right*).

Curated Project: Pancake Society



A Saturday think tank/support group/artistic intervention space in which we spend the day cooking and eating pancakes together while discussing current issues in society and imagining possible interventions. Recent topics include: race, war, capitalism, sexual harassment, and assault during protests. We are currently creating documentation to help interested people and communities to organise their own similar events.

Additional Images from past programs

